



12th (Prince of Wales's) Light Dragoons
Napoleonic Living History Unit

Rules And Regulations For The Sword Exercise Of The Cavalry.

General Information

1. Cuts.

There are only six ways of directing the edge of the blade; therefore the different parts of the body, which may be exposed by the unskilfulness of a swordsman are not be (erroneously) conceived as admitting of so many distinct cuts. The act of the wrist and shoulder alone directs the blade: and they admit but of six movements, from which every cut is derived, wherever maybe it's particular application to the body. Of the six cuts, four are made in diagonal directions, and two horizontally.

To make a cut with effect, and at the same time without exposing the person, there are two points which principally demand attention. The first is, to acquire a facility in giving motion to the arm by means of the wrist and shoulder without bending the elbow; for in bending the elbow, the sword arm is exposed; circumstances of which your opponent will ever be ready to take his advantage, as a cut in that quarter may be made with the greatest security; and if it be well directed, with the most fatal effect, as it at once decides the issue of the contest.

The next object is to attain a correctness in applying the edge in the direction of the blade, otherwise it will turn in hand; and as in that case the flat part must receive the whole force of the blow, it will in all likelihood be shivered to pieces.

2. Guards.

Of the eight guards against cavalry, five are for the protection of the rider and his horse in front, and three for the purpose of covering them, when under the necessity of retiring.

The principal position is distinguished from the rest by the term guard, and the remaining seven by that of protect.

There are two other positions for the defence of the horsemen in front; namely, the left and right protect. They consist simply in moving the sword-arm To the left and right of the bridle hand.

The position during known by the term Hanging Guard, protects the horse's head on the nearside; and on the offside, it is covered by a guard very similar to the right protect.

The first of the three retiring guards is for the protection of the bridle arm, and the left side to the rear; the second for that of the right arm and shoulder: last, which is the St George, concludes the eight guards, and is intended for the protection of the back of the head.

3. The Point.

The point should seldom or never be given in the attack, but be principally confined to the pursuit, when it can be applied with effect and without risk.

The case is different in acting against infantry, as the person against whom you then direct your point is so much below your own level, that the weight of the sword is not felt; consequently it is managed with greater facility than with an extended arm carried above the level of the shoulder.

Therefore in many instances, against infantry, the point maybe used with this much effect as the edge, and with the same degree of security.

4. The cut and guard against infantry.

In that part of the Sword exercise which relates solely to its application against infantry, there are three movements, the point, the parry, and the cut. The execution of the two latter movements differs from the mode laid down in the general rules for practice. This difference is occasionally by the relative situation of the contending parties.

A person on horseback is elevated so much above those acting on foot, that it is necessary for him to bend his elbow, in order to take a sweep to give his cut with effect. This may be securely done, as the sword-arm is not exposed in the contest. Only the four diagonal cuts can be applied against infantry: cuts one and four are made on the nearside, and two and three on the offside of the horse. The thrust of a bayonet is parried, whether made on the near, or offside, by forcing backward or forward as circumstances may direct; only it is to be observed, that the parry is made with the back of the blade instead of exposing the edge.

5. Sword Knot.

No sword must be made use of without having the sword knot attached to it. It enables a person instantly to recover his weapon, if forced from his grasp; and in drills, prevents accidents which are liable to occur by the sword escaping from the hand, when not restrained.

In whatever form the sword knot may be worn, it is always to be loosened the moment a Dragoon becomes mounted, in order to its being in readiness for use, whenever swords are required to be drawn.

Drawing Of Swords.

The Sword will be drawn, and brought to the position in which it is to be carried, in three motions.

“Draw swords!”



Position 1



Position 2



Position 3 (the carry)

On the word “swords” being uttered, direct the eyes to the sword hilt, bringing the right hand with a sharp action across the body and over the bridle arm to the sword knot, placing it upon the wrist, and giving the hand a couple of turns inwards, in order to make it fast, at the same time seize the hilt, and wait in this position for the second motion, which will be made by the fleugel man on the right, the back of a hand is to be to the rear.

Draw the sword from the scabbard with a full extended arm, at the same time sink the hand till the hilt of the Sword is immediately under the chin, that the blade perpendicular, and the back of the hand outwards.

Bring the hilt down to be in a line with the bridle hand, the elbow near the body the blade perpendicular and the wrist in a small degree rounded, which turns the edge inwards in the direction the horse's left ear.



(Detail of making sword knot fast)



Side view of Position 2)

Sloping Of swords.
"Slope swords!"



Keep the sword-arm in the exact position pointed out for carrying of the Sword; but distend the second, third, and fourth fingers from the grip of the sword, in order that the back of the blade may meet the hollow of the right shoulder, where it is to be supported with the edge directed to the front.

When in this position, the sword will be kept steady, and is to be without motion, at whatever pace the horse may be moving.

(The Carry)



Returning Of Swords

"Return swords!"



Position 1



Position 2



Position 3 (attention)

The sword is always to be returned from the carried position, and not from the sloped. This is likewise executed in three motions, dressing by the right.

Carry the Sword hilt to the hollow of the left shoulder, having the back of the hand outwards and the blade perpendicular, without pausing. Club the blade (but not the hand) to the rear close by the left shoulder, directing the eyes to the scabbard, in which the blade is immediately to be placed and returned until the hand and the elbow become in a line with each other, square across the body, and keeping the back of a hand directed to the rear.

Thrust the sword home into the scabbard and loosen instantly the sword knot from the wrist, keeping the hand upon the hilt.

On the motion from the fleugel man, carry the right hand from the hilt with the smart action to the offside.



(Detail of motion 2 (inserting the sword into the scabbard))

Positions of the Sword

"Prepare To Guard!"



This is performed in one motion, and done by bringing extremity of the sword hilt up to the pit of the stomach, with the back of the hand outwards: the flat of the blade to the face, and carried perpendicularly. At the same instant the bridle hand must cross the body in a similar direction, and immediately under the sword hand, keeping the nails inwards and hand closed.

Let it be observed throughout the drill exercise, that each cut ends with bringing the sword back to its position in the guard, from which the recruit, without waiting for any previous word from the drill officer, will come immediately down to the prepare to guard. This is to be continued as long as the motions are executed by repetition of numbers.

"Guard!"



From the motion prepare to guard, the guard is done at once, by darting the sword hand forward with the same force, as in making a blow directed to the left ear of the opponent. This will cause the back of the blade to be towards the face; the edge of the sword should be turned in a trifling degree down, in order that the side iron of the hilt may protect the wrist and under part of the arm. The sword to be kept nearly in a horizontal position across the face, the point carried rather above the level of the mounting, and in an exact parallel to the front.

The sight to be directed towards the antagonist, between the ear of the sword and the blade. In this position the arm should be distended to the utmost, and of course the hand above the level of the shoulder. The bridle hand always remains across the body, in the position of holding the bridle, except when the swords are sloped. In the guard, the greatest attention must be paid to the correct position of the hand, which must always be directed to the left ear of the antagonist, notwithstanding any change of position on his part. From guard correctly taken there is no risk in attacking, because the sword hilt is immediately opposed to the antagonists retort: but when a cut originates from a false position, the head by the first motion becomes exposed.

Cuts

We now come to the first cut, in performing which the blade takes four distinct positions, which when perfectly executed, are not discernible, as the quickest of action in the wrist gives the appearance of being only one motion.

It is to be remarked that the first motion in every cut consists in bringing the blade back to gather a sweep, at the same instant placing it in the direction in which it is to be applied, and the last motion brings the blade back to the guard.

Cut 1 in Four Motions.



From the guard, upon the word one, the sole action of the wrist, draw back the blade so as to bring the point in a perpendicular line with the outside of the right shoulder, for the purpose of making a sweep: taking care at the time, to turn the joints of the fingers in the same direction the cut is to be made, which will be in a diagonal course, as from one to four.

The recruit is to apt to sink his hand, or draw it from the guard, upon the first motion of the cut; attention must therefore be paid to his hand being steady, always covering his head with the hilt of his sword, whatever changes of position his blade may take in performing the different cuts.

It is to be considered an invariable rule, the direction of the finger joints regulates the edge of the blade.

By a quick motion of the wrist downwards, with proper attention to direct the point to the No. 1, the blade will be conducted to No. 4

Turn the wrist inwards, dropping the point so as to bring the blade in a diagonal line across the body, with the edge outwards.

Bend the back of the hand inwards, bringing the flat of the blade towards the face, and carrying on the motion of the wrist, till blade arrives at its original position in the guard, taking care at the same time, that in raising the blade, it makes a sweep inwards just to clear the elbow of the bridle hand.

Cut 2 In Four Motions



The second cut is made upon the principle of the preceding one. The blade takes four distinct positions and will be in the drill practice treated accordingly. Upon the word one, retire the blade across the face, till point becomes merely perpendicular to the elbow of the bridle hand. By the action of the wrist conduct the blade in the diagonal line from two to three, observing in the execution thereof, all the rules laid down in the preceding lesson for conducting the edge and finger joints.

Turn the wrist to the right, till it has brought the back of the hand under, the nails of the fingers and inside seam of the right sleeve upwards; at the same time keeping a firm grasp of the sword, relax the other three fingers, which will occasion the point to sink and the blade to arrive in a diagonal position, with the edge outwards.

Turn the hand to the left till it brings the sword to its original position in the guard, observing well that it makes a sweep around the right shoulder clear of the head.

Cut 3 in three motions



Drop the point outwards to the right by turning the wrist in that direction and relaxing the grasp of the three fingers of the sword hand, keeping at the same time a firm hold with the forefinger and thumb this will bring the blade in a diagonal line, with the back of the blade towards the body

Conduct the point of the sword from No. 3 to No. 2 by bending the wrist towards the face and pressing upon the three distended fingers which act as a lever.

Come to the original guard by turning the nails under and back of the hand up.

Cut 4 in three motions



By turning the wrist to the left, it will drop the point in a diagonal line across the body, within three inches of the left elbow, and with the edge of the sword outwards. Carry the point from No. 4 to No. 1 diagonally by extending the hand in a direct line with the arm. Turn the back of the hand outwards to the right, carrying on the motion of the blade till it arrives the position of the guard, taking care that it does not go round the head of the right shoulder, which would make the motion wider than necessary.

Cut 5 in three motions



Cut five is made horizontally across the face from ear to ear, and executed in three motions. Carry the point of the blade round to the right, with the edge directed outwards, till it reaches a little below the level of the sword hand, and inclined towards the right shoulder. This is done by turning the back of the hand under, and bringing the nails up. Conduct the point to No. 5, horizontally across the circle which is done by inclining the hand inwards in the direction of the cut without changing the position of the nails. Turn the wrist into its proper position in the guard, by bringing the back of the hand up.

Cut 6 in three motions.



Retire the point of the blade within a foot of the left shoulder, sinking it a little below the level of the sword hand, which is done by an inclination of the wrist towards the face.

Conduct the point to No. 6 horizontally across the circle to No. 5 by carrying the hand out in that direction, keeping the back of the hand still upwards.

Bring the blade in a sweep around the right shoulder, and clear of the head to its position in the guard by turning the back of the hand under and inclining it outwards, till the blade is brought nearly to the head; then turn the back of the hand to the face, and it will conduct the blade to the guard.

Whether the cuts are executed separately or collectively, the invariable rule of keeping the hand directed to the left ear of the antagonist must be adhered to and care taken to avoid the error, to which all beginners are liable, of carrying the sword hand to the right of their head previous to making cuts 1, 3 or 5 which exposes them to return of the same cuts before any regular position of guard can be recovered. Upon the same principle they should be cautioned against inclining the hand to the left when intending to make cuts 2,4,6. It should always be remembered that the force of a stroke against a person on their own level, must be derived from the sweep of the blade and not from the motion of the arm.

Modes of Parrying.

We now arrive at the different modes of parrying to the front; they are five in number, including the one already practised under the denomination of the guard.

Left protect



From the guard, carry the sword-arm smart across the body to the left, raising the point of the blade till it becomes perpendicular; keeping the hand above the level of the shoulder: at the same instant, place the thumb on the grip between the back plate and the ear which will turn the edge of the sword to the right and the back outwards to receive the cut; the arm to be kept as far away from the body as the position will admit.

The elbow in this as well as in the next motion is to have no action whatever, as a whole must proceed from the shoulder and the wrist.

Right protect



Without changing the direction of the blade, as held on the foregoing position, carry the sword-arm briskly to the right, directing the hand to the distance of two feet from the edge of the circle above the level of the shoulder.

The utmost attention must be paid not to oppose the edge to the enemy sabre when it can be avoided; but the bevel: which can only be done by placing the thumb between the back plate and the ear of the sword, and keeping it firm in that position, the arm to be properly distended, for the purpose of resisting the force of the blow.

Horse, near side protect.



Direct the point of the blade forwards to the left of the horse's head, and in a diagonal line from the hand, which is not to droop, but be carried a little forward in order to afford the protection required either from cut one or cut three.

The edge will be upwards in this instance but it must necessarily be exposed from the nature of the guard.

Horse offside protect.



Raise the blade to it becomes perpendicular, carrying it at the same instant in a brisk motion forwards to the off ear of the horse, and in the exact position of right protect; not forgetting to place the thumb in the direction above mentioned.

Bridle arm protect.



From the position to guard carry the sword in a horizontal direction to the right the edge of the blade leading till it arrives in a right line with the point of the shoulder. Turn the back of the hand under, which will cause the edge of the blade to be upwards at the same instant, by bending the elbow and turning the wrist so as to place the palm of hand in front, the blade will be conducted to the protection of the bridle arm which position consists in having the sword hilt above the helmet, with the blade crossing the back of the head, the point of the left shoulder, and the bridle arm; its edge directed to the left and turned a little upwards in order to bring the mounting in a proper direction to protect the hand.

Sword-arm protect.



Without sinking the hand from the protection of the bridle arm, or moving the arm from its former position, carry the blade round the back of their head to the right by turning the wrist till the palm of the hand arrives opposite the helmet; the blade will then be in a diagonal line, with the point downwards directed to the right and the edge up.

St George.



Bring the blade in a horizontal direction across the top of the head, with the edge upwards and the point to the left. This is done by turning the wrist up so as to carry the blade around the back of a head to its position.

From the St George, or head protect, come to the position to guard, by making a cut to the rear which must frequently be applicable whenever the three retiring guards are so and which makes the full sweep of a semi-circle. It is done upon the principle of the 6th cut only giving edge to the rear instead of to the front.

General application of the point.

The sword has three distinct movements when opposed to the infantry; and which can only be applied in two situations, on the near or off side of the horse. The movements consist in giving point, the parry and the cut.

Left give point.



Without moving the feet, turn the head round to the left, keeping the body square to the front; at the same instant place the blade in a diagonal line across the body to the left, with the edge outwards, and the point directed as to an object considerably below your own level.

This is to be done by dropping the point immediately from the position prepare to guard, and bending the elbow to the knuckles of the sword hand or a little above the level of the ear and about six inches from the head. The forefinger and thumb are to be distended; the former on the grip between the ear and the back plate in a line with flat of the blade and the latter on the back plate in a line with the back of the blade, by which means the extremity of the sword hilt will fall into the palm of the hand; which being pressed against the three remaining fingers will give a firm purchase and the means of applying a steady point. The head will be turned to the left and eyes to the extremity of the blade.

Dart the sword down in the direction in which it was held to the utmost extent of the arm taking care not to alter the position of the hand which should have the back of the hand up.

To the rear parry in two motions.

Without changing the position of the hand extend the sword arm to the front of your usual position, in order to take a sweep with the edge of the blade upwards, and kept well out from the body, upon the supposition of being on horseback to prevent the sword from touching the horse's shoulder. Bring the arm back with a quick motion to the rear till the sword hand arrives in a line parallel to the left ear and six inches from the head at the same instant raise the point, till the blade becomes perpendicular, with the edge directed outwards to the left and back towards the face. From the position in which the blade is left in finishing the parry, bring it back to the position in the guard; carrying the edge with a good sweep outwards, taking care not to cross with your blade parallel to your will proper front, considerably above the level of the horse's head; otherwise the animal would be in danger of receiving the cut.

Front give point



Face to the right, by turning on the heels; at the same time instantly retire the arm towards the ear as in giving point to the left; with this difference, that the hand is to be drawn as far back as possible, retaining exactly the same grasp of the sword. Flat of the blade to be upwards, with the edge directed to the right, keeping the point horizontal with the hand, and the sword carried above the peak of the helmet. The head is to be turned to the left, in the same direction with the point. Upon all occasions in giving point against cavalry the sword is to be carried above the peak of the helmet; and by pressing the blade against the helmet it will be kept steady.

Dart the hand in the direction of your proper front, then at the same time to the left about, keeping the blade still horizontal, and without changing the position of the hand, which ought be with the back upwards.

Retire the blade in its horizontal direction to the right, in doing which, bring the back of the hand under and carry the blade immediately to the cuts 5 and 6 and return to the prepare to guard from the last cut.

Right give point



Turn the head to the right as much as can be done without moving the body, which is to be kept square to the front; at the same time bring the sword hand up to the ear, having the grasp as before, with the back of the hand up, and the edge of the blade in the same direction as in making a thrust on the near side, carrying the point as much to the right as in the other instance, It was directed to the left of your usual front.

Dart the sword down to the full extent of the arm, without changing the position of the hand. Without changing the position of the hand, carry the blade towards your front to gather a sweep; in doing which turn the edge of the blade up, and the back of the hand under. This will bring the back of the blade opposite your front.

Without changing the position of the hand, by a sharp action of the sword-arm to the rear, carry the sword as far back as the arm will admit of, the hand to be on a level with the point of the shoulder, the blade carried perpendicular, and the back to the front.

From the parry, bring the sword to the proper position of the Guard, by carrying an edge with a good sweep outwards, and with the same precaution not to cross parallel to the front on account of the horse.

Source:

Rules And Regulations For The Sword Exercise Of The Cavalry. The Adjutant General's office, the War Office. Whitehall. MDCCXCVI